

Showcasing locally made handcrafted items, the Craft Gallery offers tasteful mementos to take home; some 300 bird species, many of them migrants, can be seen in Gir and its surroundings

Arif and fellow-naturalist Naman Doshi take us to the homestead of Bapu-*mian*'s family on the edge of the forest. The spacious compound is fenced with thorn bushes. In a shady corner are tethered two buffalo calves and two doe-eyed Gir calves. Doshi translates from Gujarati as Bapu-*mian* explains how his *desi* breeds are brilliantly adapted to this landscape. The grasses and wild herbs that they graze on in the forest make their milk super-nutritious. "But don't you mind when your cow is killed by lions?" we ask. Bapu-*mian*, with his leonine mane and lilting speech, gives a philosophical shrug: "The lion must eat too."

Seeing lions in Gir is a doddle. Unlike tigers, they aren't shy of humans. But to see lions as part of an intricate ecosystem that includes not only other fauna but also Maldhari pastoralists is hard to wrap one's head around. That's where Aramness's edge comes in. Its superb naturalists are expert at interpreting the landscape. Why are spider webs crowded under *ber* trees? How do you tell Gir cows from other breeds? How do Purple Sunbirds perch on flame-of-the-forest flowers? How do the nilgai spit out seeds of the *bel* fruit? Arif and Doshi made the forest and its people come alive in the best way.

Surrounded by the forest, Aramness calls itself a safari lodge but looks and feels more like an ultra-luxurious resort, with personal pools and private butlers, palatial rooms and plush decor. After an early morning flight and a three-hour drive from Rajkot, it's bliss to bury one's face in a cool moist towel on the steps to the massive haveli-style door. Inside lie 18 beautifully appointed bungalows, sunlight and shade playing on gleaming terrazzo floors. The marble bathtub is almost big enough for a Maldhari buffalo to lounge in, and I sink into scented water with a sigh of pleasure. Housekeeping is uncannily swift, a bit too much so: each time I wipe my hands on a towel, it is whisked away within minutes and replaced with another.

Later, I wake to a keen appetite and walk over to the imposing reception and dining hall, its façade clad in sandstone screens that mimic the pattern of moth-eaten teak leaves that litter the forest floor. The antipasti and salads on the small set menu are fresh and delicious. The desserts and coffee are perfect. I would have loved to sample more local cuisine—Kathiawari dishes or the subtly sophisticated Swaminarayan thali—but what's on offer is pretty good too. Like the lions, I lie back and look around in replete contentment. ■

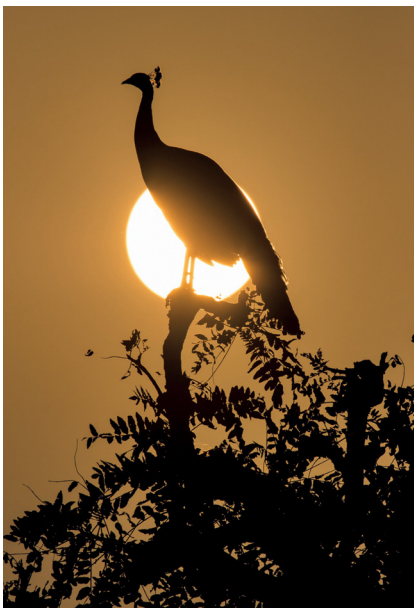
THE ESSENTIALS

Website:
https://www.aramness.com

How to get there: Aramness Gir is located right on the boundary of Sasan Gir, Gir National Park, Gujarat. The resort is a 7-hour drive from Ahmedabad, but you can also shorten your drive time by flying into Rajkot (3-hour drive), Porbandar (2.5-hour drive) or Diu (2.5-hour drive)

Tariff: Doubles from Rs 75,000 per night

Ideal time to visit: April to June is ideal for game viewing, as visibility in the park increases substantially, and with temperatures rising to 35-40 °Celsius, wildlife gather around watering holes more frequently. The mild weather from October till March helps one make the most of all available outdoor activities



VARUN TANEJA